also house General Administration. The high court will be an eight-storeyed, 55-metre structure with 2.0 million square feet, expressing the grandeur of law on a 42-acre compound. And the secretariat? Five skyscrapers! Four new highways, totalling 580 km, will service the hub. The 73 pending projects cleared by a technical review include a statue of TDP founder N.T. Rama Rao, an iconic bridge, and the Krishna River embankment road. Most works are planned to be completed in three years.

INCOMING FLIGHT OF CAPITAL

The four-phase project, with the first one estimated to cost a grand total of Rs 45,249.24 crore, will not burden the state treasury, says finance minister Payyavula Keshav. Instead, the project would be largely funded by the 4,000 acres the government intends to auction. Besides, Rs 15,000 crore has been borrowed from the World Bank; HUDCO will put up Rs 11,000 crore; other banks will lend Rs 5,000 crore.

Rhetoric is also part of the design, and luckily comes cheap. P. Narayana, municipal administration minister, says works assigned over 2014-19, during the previous TDP government, were left unfulfilled by the subsequent YSRCP regime, causing financial losses to contractors. Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, the intervening CM, had backed a tripartite capital, with Visakhapatnam, Kurnool and Amaravati as the administrative, judicial and legislative hubs. The Supreme Court blocked that proposal.

That phase also saw huge protests from farmers who had given up their land to Naidu's massive land pooling effort. Some 33,000 acres had been aggregated, farmers being promised property in the future city as well as monetary rewards. Assuagement is a key part of the script: May 2 has farmers being feted on stage by Modi. Narayana sunnily forecasts "one of the five best cities of the world". No one will be hyper if even half that hype is realised. ■

Takeaways

- **Designed as a jobs and tourism hub, Amaravati will have nine theme cities and 27 townships**
- **Coming soon: a modern assembly, high court, CMO, a 'five-skyscraper' secretariat, highways**



Chandrababu Naidu ▶

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

AKHILESH WIDENS HIS PARTY'S TENT



DALIT IS RIGHT Akhilesh Yadav backs MP Ramji Lal Suman's firebrand speech

ANI

A pronounced Dalit tilt is the new script for the SP chief. The BSP and BJP, both rivals for that space, watch with alarm as the party rouses the rabble

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

THE SAMAJWADI PARTY HAS NEVER ERRED MUCH ON THE side of subtlety. But its recent self-positioning bristles with such audacity—and in such a conscious direction—that a blueprint can be discerned. A series of remarks by its Dalit leaders has lit up Uttar Pradesh's charged political and social landscape with frequent sparks of outrage. Strikingly, however, instead of distancing itself, the party has doubled down on these statements. This combative stance suggests less a case of random, off-the-cuff remarks, more a strategic charge aimed at reshaping UP's fragmented